

Art, AI, and Conservatism
By Jake Longshore
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Art is difficult to define. I do not think art requires meaning (Pollock, *Number 18*), or that it must be aesthetically pleasing (Munch, *Angry Dog*), or that it must necessarily be difficult to create (Malevich, *Black Square*). My definition of art are those things that human beings create *with the intention* to create art. This lack of human intention is what prohibits artificial intelligence (AI) from creating artwork, and the more AI that is used in a human creation, the less of a work of art that creation is. Worse so than that, the use of AI to imitate human creativity cheapens and degrades our cultural valuing of art, something that has always existed but has now reached a nearly terminal inflection.

In a Burbank, California bar, I ran into a gentleman who had recently lost their job due to the infectious nature of cheap AI programs running rampant in the modern creative industries. Rather than lamenting, I had now just met the first person brave enough to admit to me that they outsource their imagination to a computer program in their bid to keep up with the Jones's.

Am I coming in too hot?

"It's a tool," they said early in the conversation, "and I agree that if you just write a prompt and use what it spits out, that isn't art. But that's not what I do."

I enthusiastically accepted their offer to view a video they had created with the help of AI, and God would make me an angel due to how well I held my tongue. It looked genuinely awful. The setting of the video was a very generic looking old-timey movie credit intro, starring a buttery smooth AI generated little girl who speaks and dances by herself and with a dancing demon model, before ending. It's explained that the dancing girl was done using motion capture, the model was created using AI, and the 2005-demo-esque demon dance was from an online sample that was pushed through an AI program to render for the video.

"So that there is my issue with using AI in art," I said, giving credit for the sampling of the original demon dance (creatives have done that since forever with human creations), "because when you run content through an AI algorithm, whatever gets spit out isn't something you created. It is a black box that you don't have control over, and the end product is not art."

This concluding line of his before I politely ended the conversation shocked, and alerted me to something new:

“When I’m in a team, and someone makes something for the project and they give it to me to implement, that’s a black box too. I don’t know what was going on inside their mind.”

This was an argument I was not prepared to hear. That the output from a computer program and a human are equal in his eyes. That a painting by Van Gogh would be just as art worthy if *The Starry Night* had been generated in a web browser. That a human being is only hired for creative work because they just need a body to put pen to paper, and now they can finally be replaced by a computer that can do “the same thing”. In reference to his earlier quote then, it must be in shades of grey that AI can be used to make art and if you only use a little bit, it’s okay. I assert that if a creation is still only 10% AI generated, that means it can only be 90% art, at best.

This idea of individual replaceability when it comes to creating art already exists. When children look at a Jackson Pollock and say, “I can do that, it’s just paint poured on a canvas”, or laughing at Kazimir Malevich and just how oh-so simple it is to paint an entire canvas black, we are witnessing the same degradation of human imagination that AI is now leading people to believe even more heavily. Pollock did something new. Malevich did something new. And they both did it with their own human minds. What shade of black to use, what size canvas, how high to drop the paint from, how to move the can, every decision was made by a human being.

In contrast, and in reference to the video I was shown, no endless prompting of words can ever do justice to what the pure conscious and unconscious human brain can create. The AI created a little girl, and you did the dance. But did you, or the AI, decide: the girl should be this age. She should be this shade of white. Her eyes should be brown. Her hair should be fourteen inches long and straight, and dirty blonde but not too dark, she should be five feet tall. Her eyes should close just this exact amount when she smiles, and her voice should be this exact pitch. The background setting is one particular shade of yellow-white, and the text specific shades of red and grey, and every other minor ornamentation.

In this era of tech industry supremacy, we are seeing an aggressive defunding of the arts and humanities, and for decades our children have been told that you go to college and learn STEM for the money, and you should never waste college learning anything else purely for the sake of learning. Although he did his best to dance around my inquiries, it was clear that the man I was speaking to was a conservative. I bring this up in relation to this piece because conservatism abhors creativity, newness, of breaking the mold, of human individual self-expression, and this is what the use and development of AI in artistic pursuits is all about. To replace the tumultuous waves of human creativity, forever and always leading to new expressions of the human experience, with a cheaper imitation that some expect us to be satisfied by. By

it's nature, AI cannot create something new. It can only ever create what it has been learned on. To use, and I fear depend on, AI for the advancements of human expression is a dangerous folly that we must not allow ourselves to partake in or support.

Citations:

Jackson Pollock, *Number 18*, 1950, Solomon R. Guggenheim Museum, New York City, USA.

Edvard Munch, *Angry Dog*, 1938-1943, Munch Museum, Oslo, Norway.

Kazimir Malevich, *Black Square*, 1915, State Tretyakov Gallery, Moscow, Russia.